Sensory Series: Sound

In short

Everyday office noise can be overwhelming for some neurodivergent people. Blocking it out takes a lot of energy. Keeping noise down, using meeting rooms for long chats, and respecting headphones all help.

Overview

Sound affects people in completely different ways. For many neurodivergent individuals, everyday workplace noises aren't just distracting; they can be physically overwhelming. This is often due to sensory processing differences, where the brain can't easily filter out background noise.

An open-plan office can quickly fill with noise from every side. Things like keyboards clicking, loud chats, or a humming air conditioner take up a huge amount of mental energy. Some people might experience 'misophonia', where specific sounds trigger a strong stress reaction. Others might have trouble understanding speech when there's background noise, which makes collaboration extra challenging.

Creating a workspace that's comfortable for everyone's sensory needs is essential for a productive team.

Colleagues can support each other by being mindful of volume in shared spaces. It's always best to move long conversations to a meeting room or a breakout area. Respecting when someone is wearing headphones is also important, as it's often their way of creating a quiet space of their own so they can focus.

Useful links

- Autism and sensory processing
- Misophonia
- Auditory Sensitivity: Signs, Causes, Overload and How to Help